

The Experience and Its Reflection

A Reflection on Travel, Photography, Attention, Memory, and Mediated Experience

September 2, 2026

Overview

While watching a travel video, I became interested in something that had relatively little to do with the destination itself. Two people appeared to be traveling together, but throughout much of the footage one of the individuals seemed to be continuously occupied with his phone.

What struck me was the contrast between the environment surrounding him and where his attention appeared to be directed.

The scenery was beautiful. The production quality was high. There was architecture, landscape, and an unfamiliar environment available to experience directly. Yet I continually found myself thinking: Put the phone in your pocket and look around.

This was not because I believe people should avoid photography when traveling. I understand wanting photographs and videos from an important trip. I would want photographs myself. My concern is what happens when capturing the experience begins to replace experiencing it.

The Photograph Is Not the Experience

One thought kept occurring to me while watching:

The picture you are taking is not this experience. It is a reflection of this experience.

A photograph can preserve something meaningful. It can help communicate where someone went, remind them of something they saw, and allow them to revisit a moment years later.

But the photograph is still not the moment itself.

The actual experience contains far more information than the photograph can preserve: spatial scale, movement, weather, sound, architecture, conversation, atmosphere, bodily sensations, unexpected observations, and the person's own thoughts and emotions at the time.

The photograph captures a selection.

The experience is everything surrounding that selection.

That distinction matters to me.

A Question I Would Ask After the Trip

One way I found myself evaluating the situation was to imagine the person returning home.

Suppose someone asked:

What did you see?

What was the architecture like?

What surprised you?

What neighborhoods did you walk through?

What was the weather like?

What did the place sound like?

What did you notice that you had never seen before?

What did you and the person traveling with you talk about?

What made the destination feel different from home?

I would find it deeply disappointing to have traveled somewhere extraordinary and discover that my primary answer was essentially:

“I don’t really remember, but I have it on my phone.”

The phone may contain evidence that I was physically present.

That does not necessarily mean that I was psychologically present.

Documentation Versus Presence

I therefore do not see this as an argument against taking photographs.

The distinction I would make is between documenting an experience and substituting documentation for the experience.

Healthy documentation might look like this:

I encounter something extraordinary.

I stop.

I actually look at it.

I notice details.

I experience it.

I take several photographs.

Then I put the camera away and continue experiencing the place.

In that situation, photography supports the experience.

A different situation occurs when much of someone's attention becomes devoted to continually operating the device—framing photographs, checking the screen, recording video, reviewing footage, posting content, responding to messages, or moving through the environment primarily through a display.

At that point, the relationship can become inverted.

Instead of:

Experience → Documentation

it begins to resemble:

Documentation → Experience

The person starts experiencing the destination for the purpose of producing its representation.

That is a fundamentally different relationship with the environment.

Physical Presence and Attentional Presence

Someone can therefore be physically present somewhere without being fully attentionally present.

A person might be standing in Japan, on a cruise ship, inside a cathedral, on a mountain trail, or in an unfamiliar city while a significant portion of their attention remains directed toward a digital interface.

Their geographic location has changed.

Their attentional environment has not necessarily changed with it.

That distinction became particularly noticeable to me in the video because the individual occasionally appeared almost unaware of the environment surrounding him.

Whether that impression accurately represented his entire trip is impossible to determine from the completed video. Nevertheless, that is what the final production communicated to me.

The Additional Layer: What the Audience Actually Sees

My previous coursework in film also affected how I interpreted what I was watching.

A finished film or video is not simply reality placed on a screen.

There is first an event.

Then someone records portions of that event.

Then someone selects portions of those recordings.

Therefore, at least three different things exist:

The lived event

What actually happened.

The recorded event

What cameras happened to capture.

The edited event

What someone ultimately decided the audience should see.

These are not identical.

Hundreds of moments may occur during a trip that never appear in the finished production. Camera placement influences what can be seen. Framing determines what exists inside and outside the image. Editing determines which moments survive into the final version.

Lighting, sound, sequencing, pacing, and other production choices further influence how audiences interpret what they see.

Because I have studied some of these elements—including three-point lighting and aspects of film production—I often find myself thinking not only about what is on screen but also about the decisions that produced what is on screen.

Why the Editing Choice Interested Me

This created another question.

Perhaps the individual was not actually on his phone throughout the entire trip.

Maybe there were hours in which both travelers interacted, explored, talked, and paid close attention to their surroundings.

But if so, the production still repeatedly selected footage in which one person appeared absorbed in his phone.

That itself is an interesting creative choice.

Out of everything that could have represented the trip, those moments became part of the final representation.

Consequently, as an audience member, I received an unusual image:

A person was physically moving through an extraordinary environment while apparently directing substantial attention toward a small screen.

The contrast between those two realities became more interesting to me than whatever destination the video was originally trying to showcase.

The Missing Relationship

I also noticed something else.

There were supposedly two people traveling together, yet I rarely saw them meaningfully represented together.

That seemed strange.

Travel is not merely geographical. When people travel together, the relationship between the travelers becomes part of the experience.

There are conversations, discoveries, shared jokes, disagreements, reactions, and moments in which one person points something out to the other.

If the final product repeatedly shows one person looking at a phone rather than the travelers interacting, then something important about the human dimension of the trip disappears as well.

Again, that may be an editing artifact rather than an accurate depiction of the entire journey.

But the final production is nevertheless what an audience receives.

Memory and Being Able to Tell the Story

For me, one test of meaningful travel would be whether I could later tell someone about it without consulting my camera roll.

I would want photographs.

But I would also want memories.

I would want to be able to describe the architecture.

I would want to remember walking through particular places.

I would want to recall what surprised me.

I would want to remember what something looked like beyond the rectangular boundaries of a photograph.

I would want to remember what happened immediately before and after the photograph was taken.

Most importantly, I would want the photographs to reactivate memories I already possessed rather than function as substitutes for memories I never formed.

Japan as an Example

Japan is a useful example because it is somewhere I would personally love to visit.

I enjoy watching walking videos from Japan, particularly footage involving rain, snow, and different urban or natural environments.

If I ever traveled there, I would absolutely take photographs.

I would probably take quite a few.

But I also suspect I would become relatively unreachable.

There would be an enormous amount that I would want to observe directly: architecture, transportation systems, streets, landscapes, weather, stores, public spaces, signs, technological infrastructure, cultural differences, and ordinary details that might never appear in a conventional travel guide.

I would not want to spend thousands of dollars and travel thousands of miles merely to relocate my normal relationship with my phone to another country.

I would want the destination itself to become the center of my attention.

Photography as Selection Rather Than Substitution

There is another reason I do not reject photography itself.

Photography can actually require careful observation.

A photographer may notice lighting, composition, geometry, symmetry, texture, contrast, or architectural features that another observer misses completely.

Someone practicing photography intentionally can therefore become extremely attentive to an environment.

The distinction is not simply:

Camera versus no camera.

It is:

Intentional observation versus continuous technological mediation.

Photography can become a method of looking more carefully.

It can also become a method of avoiding looking directly.

Which one occurs depends greatly on how the technology is being used.

A Personal Principle

The principle I take from the experience is therefore relatively simple:

Capture enough of an experience to help preserve it, but do not spend so much effort preserving the experience that you fail to have it.

A camera should help me remember where I have been.

It should not become the reason I failed to notice where I was.

The ideal relationship would be something like:

Observe → Experience → Understand → Capture → Put the device away → Continue experiencing.

Rather than:

See → Record → Check screen → Record → Check screen → Move → Record → Return home.

The Difference Between Evidence and Memory

There is also a philosophical distinction here that I find interesting.

A photograph can provide evidence:

I was there.

Memory can provide something different:

I experienced being there.

Those statements sound similar, but they are not equivalent.

A person can possess thousands of digital records demonstrating that an event occurred while retaining surprisingly little understanding of what the event actually felt like.

Digital storage and human memory perform different functions.

The existence of one does not guarantee the quality of the other.

Broader Observation

This may extend well beyond tourism.

Modern technology makes it increasingly easy to create representations of life continuously.

Photos, videos, posts, messages, location histories, and other digital records can create an extraordinarily detailed external archive.

That archive can be valuable.

But there is a paradox:

The more effort someone devotes to constructing a record demonstrating that life is being lived, the more attention may sometimes be removed from the life being documented.

The danger is therefore not photography itself.

The danger is confusing the representation of an experience with the experience that the representation is supposed to preserve.

Closing Reflection

That was ultimately what interested me about the video.

I was watching beautiful footage of a place that I might personally have found fascinating, while repeatedly seeing someone whose attention appeared to be somewhere other than the environment surrounding him.

Perhaps the complete trip was nothing like the final video suggested.

That possibility is important because editing itself creates a representation.

Nevertheless, the finished production made me think about something larger:

There is a difference between traveling somewhere, recording that you traveled somewhere, and actually experiencing where you traveled.

Ideally, all three can coexist.

But if I ever have to choose between possessing a perfect recording of an extraordinary place and possessing the memory of actually standing there and paying attention to it, I would rather have the memory.

The photograph should be the reflection.

The life being reflected should remain the primary experience.